

EMBER — Visual UI Plan v2 (HUD/specimen aesthetic — supersedes v1 below)

**New direction: one living specimen,
annotated like a lab readout, not a
scattered field of dots.**

Reference pulled directly from a studio portfolio site (Sutéra, "Reality By Design") — the winning elements to steal: (1) ONE central evolving object, not many small ones, (2) thin leader-lines connecting the object to small technical text callouts around it, (3) a top-bar toggle that changes the *entire rendering mode* of the same underlying data, (4) monospace data-readout typography contrasted against one bold display headline. This reads as "designer studio tool" instantly — far stronger first impression than a garden or particle field alone, and it's the actual reason that reference feels premium.

THE SPECIMEN

Instead of one ember per entry scattered across a canvas, **all entries feed ONE evolving central shape** — think of it as your emotional signature rendered as a single abstract bloom/form (SVG, built from layered soft blob paths, not a literal flower). Each new entry subtly reshapes it: petal/lobe count or spread increases, color temperature shifts toward warm or cool based on the entry's zone+intensity, overall size grows slightly. The specimen is ALWAYS on screen, center stage, large — it's not one node among many, it IS the interface.

This is more buildable than 50+ independently-animated embers, and it's more "wow" — one thing to get right and polish, not many things to get right at once.

ANNOTATION SYSTEM (the actual "wow" — steal this exactly)

Around the specimen, thin 1px lines extend outward to small monospace text callouts, exactly like the reference:

- **Top-left callout:** current state label, e.g. `SU (UNDERNEATH) — HELD, NOT HIDDEN` — a short poetic/technical hybrid line summarizing the CURRENT overall emotional signature (derived from recent entries' average zone/intensity)

- **Right-side callout:** most recent `reflection_line`, shown as if it's a live readout, with a small timestamp under it in monospace (`ZUR 05:04 AM` style — use the user's actual local time)
- **Bottom-left callout:** small stat block — total entries, rough split (e.g. `62% HELD LOW · 38% HELD HIGH`), styled like a data panel, not a progress bar with judgment attached
- On tap/hover of the specimen itself, the annotation lines animate to a DIFFERENT past entry, swapping the right-side callout text — this is your "browse the archive" interaction, same payoff as v1's tap-to-relive but visually integrated into the HUD language instead of separate floating embers

THE "CHANGE REALITY" TOGGLE

Top-center toggle switches the specimen's rendering mode between two states (two, not three — keep build scope real):

1. **"Held"** — organic mode: soft blob/bloom shape, warm-to-cool gradient fill, calm
2. **"Signal"** — data mode: same underlying shape rendered as a sparse point-cloud/wireframe (like the third reference image), monospace coordinates ticking subtly nearby — this is the

"technical craft" flex moment, cheap to fake (just swap fill for a dot-grid stroke pattern on the same path), high visual payoff

Toggling between them on the same specimen (not two separate screens) is the single most impressive, most "wow," and most reference-faithful moment you can build — prioritize this over anything else new.

TYPOGRAPHY (matches reference exactly)

- Headline: bold, tight-tracked geometric sans (e.g. "Space Grotesk" or "General Sans"), large, e.g. `REALITY, BY DESIGN` energy → for Ember: `HELD, BY DESIGN` or similar as the top-left headline
- All callouts, timestamps, stats: monospace (`JetBrains Mono` or `IBM Plex Mono`), small, uppercase, letter-spaced — this contrast (bold display + tiny monospace data) is what makes the reference feel like a lab tool instead of an app

COLOR

- Base: near-black `#0a0a0d` , or near-white `#f7f6f2` for "Held" mode light variant if you want the two-tone light/dark contrast from the reference's first vs. second screenshot

- Specimen gradient: cool violet-blue (#4a5a8f) for heavy-leaning signature → warm coral/amber (#e8895a) for light-leaning signature
- Callout lines/text: low-opacity grey (#888), NOT colored — keep all HUD chrome neutral so the specimen is the only color in the frame

BUILD PRIORITY UNDER TIME PRESSURE (do these in order, stop anywhere and still have a demo)

1. Static specimen SVG (single blob/bloom shape) + one annotation callout, no toggle yet
 2. Wire specimen color/shape to real entry data (zone + intensity average)
 3. Add the CHANGE REALITY toggle (Held ↔ Signal point-cloud swap) — this is the single highest-impact feature, prioritize it over more callouts
 4. Add tap-to-browse-past-entries on the specimen
 5. Only if time remains: entry-submission animation (specimen briefly pulses/reshapes live on new entry)
-

V1 PLAN (fallback if the specimen approach proves too slow to build — simpler, still fine)

**Core visual metaphor: NOT a garden.
A dusk sky with embers.**

Reject the literal "plant a tree" cliché — every wellness app does gardens. Instead: **the whole screen is a slow, dark horizon at dusk**. Every entry becomes a single glowing ember/spark that drifts down and settles onto that horizon. Over time the horizon fills with light — your own constellation of days.

1. LAYOUT

Full-bleed canvas, no card/container chrome. The interface IS the world, not a UI sitting on top of a world.

- **Top third:** empty dark space (this is where new sparks drift down from)
- **Middle:** a single soft **horizon line** — not straight, gently undulating (like a slow sine wave, animated

at ~20s period, barely perceptible – it should feel alive, like breathing, not obviously animated)

- **Below horizon:** darker still, reflective – embers that land near the horizon cast a faint mirrored glow downward (cheap to fake: a blurred, flipped, lower-opacity copy of the ember layer)
- **Input field:** docked at the very bottom, minimal – a thin glowing line that expands into a text field on tap/click, recedes when not in use. Never a boxy form sitting on the scene.

2. THE ZONE SYSTEM – replace binary left/right split with a VERTICAL gradient

Instead of "two sides" (reads as literal/judgmental – good side vs bad side), use **height above the horizon**:

- **Heavy/negative entries** → embers land LOW, close to the horizon line, colored deep indigo/violet-red (like dying coals: #3b1f3d → #7a2e3d)
- **Light/positive entries** → embers land HIGH, drift further up before settling, colored warm gold/amber (#f4a259 → #ffd27a)
- **Intensity, not just binary sentiment**, controls exact height + color saturation – this requires the Reflector to output a rough 0–1 intensity score

alongside zone, not just "positive/negative". Worth the extra prompt complexity — it's what makes the world feel like a real gradient of a life instead of two buckets.

Result: after a week of entries, the user sees an actual **vertical constellation** — a visual autobiography of intensity and mood, not a left/right diagram.

3. EMBER RENDERING (keep this cheap to build — CSS/SVG, no asset files)

Each ember = one small radial-gradient circle (8–14px depending on intensity), with:

- A soft outer glow (`box-shadow` or SVG `feGaussianBlur`)
- Gentle idle flicker: subtle opacity pulse, randomized phase per ember (staggered `animation-delay`) so the whole field feels alive, not synced/robotic
- On creation: ember spawns at top of screen, drifts down with slight horizontal drift (not straight line — use a simple easing curve or 2-3 keyframe waypoints), settles at its final height, then flicker-idle begins

On tap/hover of any past ember: it flares brighter for a moment and the `reflection_line` for that entry fades in as small text nearby, then fades out. This turns the whole accumulated world into a browsable memory — a real payoff for the "seen" feeling, and a genuinely novel interaction most judges won't have seen in this hackathon's project pool.

4. THE MICRO-ACTION MOMENT

After submitting, before the ember settles, show the `reflection_line` and `micro_action` as an overlay card that fades in over the darkened canvas — full attention, no distraction — then fades out as the ember begins its drift-down animation. This sequencing (attention → release → settle) is the emotional pacing of the whole interaction; don't show the ember animation and the text at the same time, let one hand off to the other.

5. TYPOGRAPHY

- **Reflection line:** one serif display font (e.g. "Fraunces" or "Playfair Display" via Google Fonts), large (28-36px), centered, generous line height — this is the emotional focal point of the whole app
- **Micro-action:** small sans-serif underneath, muted color, feels like a quiet aside, not a command

- **Everything else (input placeholder, nav, etc.):**
minimal, low-opacity, gets out of the way

6. COLOR PALETTE (exact hex, dark-mode base)

- Background base: #0a0a12 → #12121c (near-black, slight blue undertone)
- Horizon line glow: #2a2a3d
- Negative-zone embers: #7a2e3d → #3b1f3d (dying coal, deep red-violet)
- Positive-zone embers: #ffd27a → #f4a259 (warm gold-amber)
- Reflection text: #f5f0e8 (warm off-white, not pure white — softer)
- Micro-action text: #8a8a9a (muted grey-violet)

7. MOTION PRINCIPLES (the "very creative" part is really about restraint + one signature motion, not many effects)

- **One signature motion:** the ember drift-and-settle. Everything else should be still or barely perceptible (horizon breathing, idle flicker). A calm scene with one meaningful motion reads as more

crafted than a busy scene with many small animations — and it's far less build time.

- No page transitions, no loading spinners — the darkness itself is the loading state (fade canvas in slowly on load while `/world` fetches).

8. WHY THIS IS ACTUALLY DIFFERENT FROM "GENERIC WELLNESS APP UI"

- Rejects the two clichés of this exact genre: (a) garden/plant growth metaphors, (b) left/right or happy/sad binary split UI
- Vertical-intensity-as-height is a genuinely uncommon spatial metaphor for emotional data — worth stating explicitly in the demo/pitch as a deliberate design choice
- The tap-to-relive interaction on old embers turns a static archive into something explorable — this is the single feature most likely to make a judge say "I haven't seen that before," which is verbatim the Creativity & Innovation criterion's example line

9. BUILD-TIME REALITY CHECK

This is achievable with **CSS keyframes + SVG** or `<canvas>`, no game engine, no asset library.

Estimated build time for a competent frontend dev: 3-4 hours for the full canvas system (drift animation, idle flicker, tap-to-relive, horizon breathing) if scoped exactly as above and not expanded further. Do not add more effects than what's listed here under time pressure — this list is already the ceiling, not a starting point.